Alberta Votes on Whether to Hold a Separation Referendum

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People in Alberta, a **province** in western Canada, are voting on Monday. They are not deciding right away whether to leave Canada. Instead, they are deciding whether to hold a **binding referendum** on separating at a later date. A referendum is a vote where citizens decide a question directly.

The vote was called earlier this year by Alberta's leader, Danielle Smith, after a **grassroots** group gathered about 300,000 signatures on a **petition**. Another group collected more than 400,000 signatures on a **petition** against separation. About five million people live in Alberta.

Many people who support separation say the oil-rich **province**'s economy has been held back by the environmental policies of Canada's central government in Ottawa. They say Alberta would keep more of its wealth on its own.

People who want Alberta to stay, including Prime Minister Mark Carney, have called for unity. Opponents warn that a newly independent Alberta would face billions of dollars in debt and that the uncertainty could push jobs and investment away. Polls have suggested most Albertans want to remain in Canada, though the debate itself has been divisive.

A court blocked the pro-separation **petition**, saying it failed to consult Indigenous **First Nations** whose land would be affected. **First Nations** groups have called Smith's decision to let the vote go ahead "undemocratic." Smith opposes separation herself, but she says the process gives residents a chance to have their say.

If voters choose to move ahead, a **binding referendum** could happen as soon as 2027, Smith has said. Albertans are also voting on nine other questions, several about immigration. Hundreds of thousands of people voted early by mail, and early figures suggested strong **turnout**.

Word Treasure

province -- A province is a large area of a country with its own local government, like a state in the U.S.

binding referendum -- A binding referendum is a public vote whose result the government must follow.

petition -- A petition is a written request signed by many people asking leaders to take an action.

grassroots -- A grassroots group is started by ordinary people rather than by politicians or big organizations.

First Nations -- First Nations are Indigenous peoples of Canada whose communities lived there long before Canada existed.

turnout -- Turnout is how many eligible people actually vote in an election.

Background you need

Canada is divided into provinces and territories, and each province has its own government and leader, while the national government meets in Ottawa.

Alberta is a western province whose economy depends heavily on oil and gas, so national environmental rules can affect it strongly.

A referendum lets citizens vote directly on a question; Monday's vote only decides whether to start the legal process for a later binding referendum on separation.

Indigenous First Nations have rights connected to their traditional lands, which is why a court said they needed to be consulted.

Break it down

LEAD: Albertans vote on whether to hold a later binding referendum on leaving Canada
KEY EVENT: Monday's vote, called by Alberta leader Danielle Smith after a petition
+- WHO: Alberta voters, Danielle Smith, Prime Minister Mark Carney, First Nations groups
+- WHERE: Alberta, a province in western Canada
+- WHEN: Monday; a binding referendum could follow as soon as 2027
SUPPORTERS' VIEW: Ottawa's environmental policies held back the oil-rich economy
OPPONENTS' VIEW: unity, billions in debt, lost jobs and investment
EVIDENCE: 300,000 vs. 400,000 petition signatures; polls favor staying; strong early turnout
OPEN QUESTION: Will voters choose to start the legal process toward separation?

Why it matters

Whether a province stays in a country is one of the biggest choices voters can make, and Canada is a close neighbor and partner of the United States. The vote also raises questions about how Indigenous nations are consulted on decisions affecting their land.

Test what you remember

1. What are Alberta voters deciding on Monday?

- (A) Whether to leave Canada immediately
- (B) Whether to build a new oil pipeline
- (C) Who will be Canada's next prime minister
- (D) Whether to hold a binding referendum on separating at a later date

2. About how many signatures did the pro-separation petition gather?

- (A) Nine
- (B) About five million
- (C) More than 400,000
- (D) About 300,000

3. What do many separation supporters blame for holding back Alberta's economy?

- (A) Low oil prices around the world
- (B) Too many people moving away
- (C) The central government's environmental policies
- (D) Immigration rules

4. Why did a court block the pro-separation petition?

- (A) It was written in the wrong language
- (B) It had too few signatures
- (C) It was filed too late
- (D) It failed to consult Indigenous First Nations whose land would be affected

5. What is Danielle Smith's own view on separation?

- (A) She strongly supports it
- (B) She opposes it
- (C) She has not decided
- (D) She wants a vote in 2026

6. How soon could a binding referendum happen if voters move ahead?

- (A) Next month
- (B) In ten years
- (C) Never
- (D) As soon as 2027

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Separation supporters: They say Canada's central government has held back Alberta's oil-rich economy and that Alberta would keep more of its wealth on its own.

2. Prime Minister Mark Carney and opponents: They call for unity and warn that an independent Alberta would face billions in debt and lose jobs and investment.

3. First Nations groups: They called Smith's decision to let the vote go ahead after a court blocked the petition "undemocratic."

4. Alberta leader Danielle Smith: She opposes separation but says the process gives residents a chance to have their say.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):